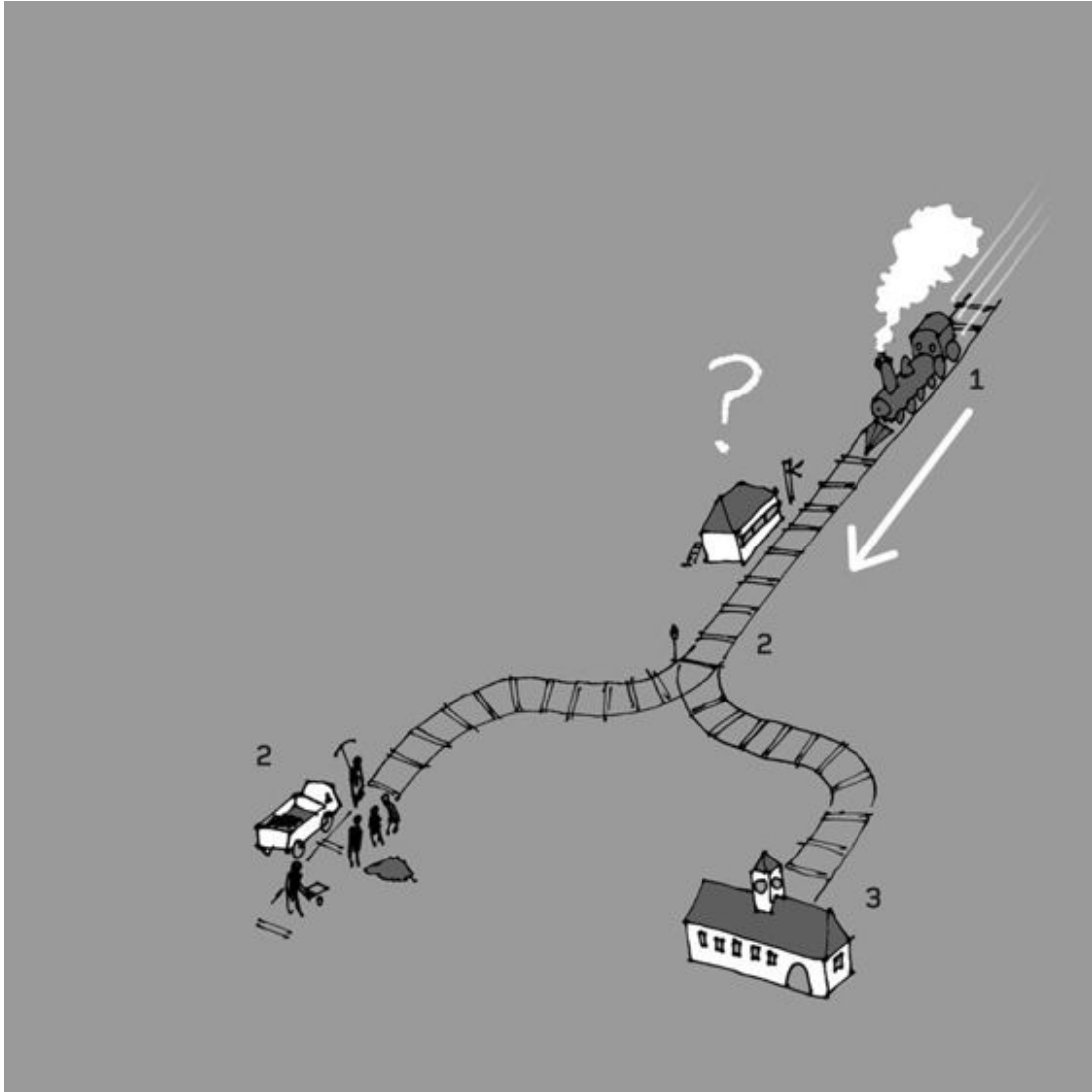


Acts and omissions

In common usage, 'ethics' refers to how we judge the morality of our actions. At the heart of any judgement we make of an action are two things: the consequences of that action, and the intention of the person making it. While the seriousness of the consequences provokes our immediate reaction, with further thought we realize that intention is crucial to deciding morality. Is a deliberate theft less morally defensible than a fatal mistake? Moral judgement is simple when both intention and consequences are bad, but not so easy to decide when serious consequences are a result of good intentions, or at least without bad intention.

Further dilemmas arise when deliberate choices have to be made. Sometimes a sacrifice has to be made for 'the greater good'; there are cases where several lives can be saved by the deliberate loss of another, for instance. But do the ends always justify the means? And is there a moral difference between deliberate action and deliberately allowing something to happen?



A runaway train **(1)** out of control and hurtling towards a final set of points **(2)**. Should the signalman take action by diverting the train onto a sideline where a group of workmen will be killed **(3)**, or is he morally less culpable if he takes no action and allows the train to speed on and ultimately crash in the statio **(4)**, killing many more people?